Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, Section 107) which allows use for commentary, criticism, news reporting, research, teaching or scholarship without requiring permission from the rights holder.

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (315) 859-4071.

Michi Fuji

Violinist Michi Fuji was born in 1990 in Toyota City, Aichi, Japan. She graduated from the Aichi Prefectural University and came to New York City in 2008. Michi received a degree from the New School for Jazz and Contemporary Music in 2011 and became a member of the Junior Mance Trio soon after.

Michi was interviewed in Clinton, New York on April 3, 2014 by Monk Rowe, director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: Well welcome to Hamilton. My name is Monk Rowe and I'm pleased to have Michi Fuji here today on the campus. I enjoyed your playing a lot last night.

MF: Thank you.

MR: Some student asked you a question I probably was going to ask — why did you come to the United States, and you simply said "I wanted to learn jazz."

MF: That's it, yeah.

MR: You couldn't stay in Japan and learn jazz then?

MF: I can learn jazz in Japan, but jazz in Japan is not original. Jazz is original in America, in New York and New Orleans. Not Japan.

MR: Someone was speaking about jazz in Japan recently and they said it was very much connected with style, and like it was a hip thing to go hear or something like that. Does that make sense?

MF: Yeah. People not really strict to study bebop or swing. They try to learn more of other things, and more new jazz. But I moved to New York — I'm going to have to learn more bebop and swing and blues.

MR: I bet you started at a young age on the violin.

MF: Yeah.

MR: Playing classical music?

MF: Yeah.

MR: Okay. Did you do any of the — was it pretty much with a teacher and learning to read music?

MF: Yes.

MR: Did you feel like you wanted to be a musician from that age? Was this something that you felt driven to do? You said something about "there wasn't anything to do so I played my violin."

MF: Right.

MR: What does that mean?

MF: When I was a kid I liked the violin — going to elementary school we started getting more busy, studied or homework. But in the kindergarten, not that much homework. I had time to play the violin a lot so I just played.

MR: I'm not sure how to ask this question, but you know with YouTubes and people see all this information. Sometimes we'll see YouTubes of very small children in Japan or South Korea, and they're playing at this incredible level. We don't see it that much from American children, at least in my exposure. Do you think that there's something to that, or is it high pressure for Japanese children to excel at music, from some parents?

MF: Yeah. Some parents really want to — are strict about education or some music. And some parents are thinking when their kids are really small that the kid's going to have to be in music, sing. So there's really strict training. Yeah.

MR: And it could be for other things too. In the *New York Times Magazine* last week there was a very long article about a young Japanese baseball player. And it talked about — his total life was baseball. He spent the summers at camps and all that.

MF: Some, yeah. Some parents and kids it's like that.

MR: Okay.

MF: But my parents, no.

MR: They weren't driven for you to be a professional violin player.

MF: Ut uh. No, I don't think so. Just as a kid I played a lot.

MR: Okay. Do you remember your first exposure to jazz music — hearing jazz for the first time?

MF: Yeah. I was I think 15 or 14 years old. I was buying the Coltrane album but I totally did not understand that music. But I was buying the CD's. And also I was going to the library and checking out some jazz music. Yeah. It was like 14, a teenager. But I no understand, just listening.

MR: But you don't have to understand it to like it.

MF: Right. It's cool.

MR: Of course when you pick out Coltrane too, that could be a little overwhelming.

MF: Yeah. Maybe the cover of the CD is cool. I don't know.

MR: Sure. You're attracted by the look of it.

MF: Yeah.

MR: So you didn't listen to violin players first?

MF: In jazz?

MR: Yeah.

MF: In jazz, later, yeah. For jazz I was listening at that time to Coltrane and Miles. Miles Davis. And then, oh I heard Stephane Grappelli. I tried to listen to that.

MR: Did you like that era of music?

MF: Yeah. I like Stephane Grappelli, and his tone and swing and his music.

MR: How did your parents feel about you going to the United States?

MF: I have a brother and a sister — I have one older brother and I have a younger sister. And my brother has a really regular, stable life. And he is living close to my parents' house also. So he is doing good. So I can be free kind of. So always my brother is kind of conservative. Like he is a boy, like a son. So he always has responsibility. But I am second so I always open the door, you know, not innovative but surviving. So my parents used to act like my attitude is so — oh New York, okay.

MR: And you came to New York specifically to go to the New School?

MF: My English still is hard, but my grades were so bad. So I was going to college, the name is St. Elizabeth's in New Jersey. In Morristown. St. Elizabeth's. I was studying English, just English there for one year in New Jersey, so I went to New York by train for one hour. And I was there one year and then moved, transferred, to the New School. And I graduated. I studied at the New School two years and a half.

MR: Did you get a degree?

MF: Yeah. I have a degree in Japan and at the New School.

MR: Okay. Your degree was in classical violin?

MF: Yeah. And in New School it's jazz.

MR: Okay. And that's where you met Junior [Mance]?

MF: Yeah.

MR: You know we have something in common, that we both like the song "Harlem Lullaby."

MF: Right.

MR: I understand you played that with him the first time you met him? Or is that not quite correct?

MF: The first time, what happened? I was just listening to his "Harlem Lullaby" over and over. And the first time Hide, me and Junior tried it I was really listening, and I played the same place Junior played, Junior had soloed. Junior had soloed. And he saw me. "That's my solo you just played." So I learned that the song doesn't have music so I just listened and played what he played. It's okay.

MR: Yeah. It's a really neat song. You give lessons?

MF: From?

MR: Do you give violin lessons?

MF: That means?

MR: Do you have students?

MF: Oh, I'm teaching but I don't teach jazz yet. This time is the first time. But I'm teaching the violin so far.

MR: And Hide said something about talking to parents when they ask about their children. Do you have students ask you about making a living in the music world? What's it like?

MF: Yeah. Sometimes they ask me can you make a life as a jazz musician? So far I'm teaching, mostly I'm teaching to play.

MR: Did you ever play on the street like Hide?

MF: Yeah, yeah, yeah. Sometimes.

MR: Well you do what you have to do I guess, as a musician. You didn't have aspirations to play in a symphony orchestra then?

MF: I did not play like seven years. But last year my friends asked me to sub for the symphony, with Beethoven's something — I forgot the number. But I did not play seven years in a symphony, but okay I try, I did it last year. So yeah I did it. So, one time in New York.

MR: It seems to me it'd be such a different thing.

MF: It's different, yeah.

MR: I mean you're in a whole section of violin players. It's all supposed to sound very cohesive and like one big instrument I guess.

MF: Yeah. In a symphony, yeah, it's different.

MR: What's your day-to-day — I asked Hide the same question — so a week for you can be various different things? You play other gigs? You have students.

MF: Um hum. I like sessions, jam sessions, and a home session, my friends ask me to come and play just sessions. I like that. And I have to practice, and teaching, and sometimes I want to work on my body to exercise.

MR: Well I know the answer to this question, but is it expensive to live in New York?

MF: But my area is not that much. It's fine.

MR: There's a professor here on campus that's writing a paper about women in jazz.

MF: Nice.

MR: Does it make a difference, that you think, that you're a woman playing jazz?

MF: Yeah, I feel different sometimes.

MR: Yes? How so?

MF: I don't know. But even playing with a woman is different. I don't know why. And always the band member is a man, right? But sometimes with a woman I feel different attitude to men, you know, the attitude. And the woman musicians I feel are different.

MR: You mean if you're in a band and there's another woman.

MF: Yeah, I feel different. I don't know why. It's different.

MR: I'm trying to imagine how it's different. Do you think the other woman might want to be the only woman in the band?

MF: I don't know. I not so much play with women. I don't have opportunity. But it's kind of different. I don't know why. And harder.

MR: Who are the violin players that you — you mentioned Django — I mean Stephane Grappelli, and anybody else you particularly like on violin?

MF: Stuff Smith, Christian Howes, Ray Nance.

MR: Christian Howes and —

MF: Ray Nance, Ray Nance. Ellington trumpeter.

MR: Oh, Ray Nance, of course. Yeah he played trumpet and violin and sang.

MF: Yeah.

MR: And what's the challenge with — did you ever play the electric violins?

MF: Ut uh. It's heavy.

MR: It's heavier, huh? What do you notice about going around the world with Junior, and how people react to jazz. Is it any different in different parts of the world?

MF: That meaning is — people react? The violin there in trio? People are kind of surprised. Regularly it's piano-bass-drums. But the violin has its own sound. But I think a violin is I think just really a sensitive instrument when compared with a horn. And Junior is really a loose style. But his style is loose but his music is really sensitive — and I don't know how, maybe sensitive, that point is the violin mixes the blues, I don't know how I think. Not naïve, not always going to power.

MR: More delicate.

MF: I think so. The point is it's good for the violin. It's not gypsy, it's not classic, the trio is, the violin that comes with Junior is the music, not going to gypsy. Classic, no. It's kind of loose and jazz sounding, and delicate.

MR: Can you recall the first time you heard about the blues. What does this blues mean?

MF: A feeling?

MR: Yeah, the feeling, and the musical form that goes along with it.

MF: Yeah, but resonant feeling and, yeah, and sing.

MR: How did you learn it?

MF: Just listening. Junior and I listen a lot to B.B. King. But yeah, just listening. But sometimes I transcribe somebody's blues and learn, but mostly listening.

MR: How do you make a violin swing?

MF: It's hard to make a violin sound swinging — I'm going to have to learn for myself how to swing the violin. But that's a different thing compared with classical. But even classical, people really swing, right? But for the techniques, you mostly have to learn by the bowing I think.

MR: Because to get the swing eighth note [scats] what is the mechanics of that?

MF: So far I think with the bow, like this move. The tone is stopped, so you've got to have something to slur. The horn section is more like smooth. But the violin always — if the bow is like this it's not good.

MR: You can't go back and forth as much.

MF: Yeah. A technique I have to learn this about. Slur and staccato. But I'm going to have to learn.

MR: Do you have advice for young musicians who want to pursue it as a career?

MF: For jazz?

MR: In any way.

MF: Just listening and just trying to play with great musicians. Just learn from the great masters.

MR: Right.

MF: And just I think getting good at playing good, one thing is practice, right? One thing is experience.

MR: A lot of people complain, well how do I get experience?

MF: Jam sessions? Play with somebody, especially good musicians.

MR: Yeah, I know Hide said that, he was talking to some bass players last night. Go to jam sessions. Can those things become very competitive?

MF: Jam sessions, competitive?

MR: Jam sessions, yeah. Or are they mostly friendly?

MF: Oh friendly, yeah. No competition.

MR: There used to be a term they called "cutting contests," where people could sort of try and make their reputation by playing better than the other person and that kind of thing.

MF: I'm not going — not that kind of jam session. Just friendly. Because it's really — the music needs to communicate with the musician. So friendly is good.

MR: Someone asked a question last night, a student, about the three of you improvising together. And I think people have a hard time understanding that most times when you're improvising you're playing over a song form. Like most of you know where you are in the song. Is that your experience?

MF: Yeah.

MR: Okay. Because sometimes students can't follow it. Or, like, how do they know when to stop? How do they know when the bridge is coming? That kind of thing.

MF: Just, they have a form, the song form. Regular is 32, right, 32-bars. Not always 32 bars. But I know always where I am when I am playing. I know.

MR: Do you like working without a drummer or does it not matter to you?

MF: I love drummers and I need to feel more drum feeling. But this trio, Junior is great at accompanying and the rhythm is real. And Hide is very great. This trio is fine. But

always I'm learning a lot of things from a drummer. Because the violin is hard to feel and play with a rhythm feel.

MR: Rhythmically?

MF: Yeah. Rhythmically phrase. So I really need a drummer feeling. I learn from the drummer a lot.

MR: And do you get calls from other musicians to play gigs?

MF: Sometimes.

MR: What kind of gigs would they be?

MF: Always — sometimes I play with a string section where I can also improvise. And then sometimes I play like harp. So I have a lot of opportunity to play with jazz string players. And sometimes my friends call me to gig and sometimes to play a session.

MR: I don't know if you can answer this question, but what's the average pay, the average money that musicians in New York expect to get these days?

MF: The amount?

MR: Yes. I know it varies from one thing to another.

MF: But rent, right? Rent and food, right?

MR: But if someone called you up and said "I have a gig" it's like playing music for a wedding reception — what would you expect the money to be for that?

MF: The amount?

MR: The amount, yes.

MF: A wedding is sometimes — if it's a wedding, maybe at least a hundred, four hundred, two hundred. In a wedding, yeah.

MR: And when you play in a jazz club?

MF: It's up to the player. Because Junior is always a good amount. But other musicians, it depends. So it's up to the musician.

MR: I asked Hide about goals. I think you heard his answer when he said there's no goals in jazz. It's like one day to the next. What about you? Do you have goals that you think "I'd like to be doing this in a few years?"

MF: Not that goal, but smaller goals. For example, I really want to know a lot of tunes. Just things. But that is not for the career, just for my ability. So I want to know the tunes. And I want to hear more harmony things from the piano or bass. That goal I always have. But I don't think about the goal of a career. More the practice way. I will learn that tune. Like that goal.

MR: Well a lot of jazz musicians have found their way into academia, teaching in colleges and so forth. Is that a goal of yours? To be a professor?

MF: Me?

MR: Yeah.

MF: I don't know if I'll have a chance. I want to do anything. But for me, if my fingers are stiff because I don't have time to practice, this is, for me, getting really frustrating. And if I couldn't play in a session it's not good. It's kind of frustrating. But if I cannot stop practicing it's all right. But to get rid of the time is not good for me. But the point, the center is the ability going up. If I can be a professor it's fine, but the center is not teaching.

MR: The center is that you continue to be a good player.

MF: But the teaching is okay.

MR: No that's a good way to put it. Because if you really get involved in teaching it might take away from your time and your effort and the whole thing. There was a brief time of fusion music in the 70's, there were some electric violin players, the Mahavishnu Orchestra. Are you familiar with any of that music? Very electric, with the violin going through —

MF: But I like Nigel Kennedy. He's electric. And he's very masterful of the classic music. But I like his treatment.

MR: What's the club scene like in New York now. I know some of them are very expensive to go to, like the Blue Note and so forth. But I imagine there's other places that are easier for the public to afford. Like Café Loup, where you play, they charge a cover?

MF: No.

MR: Oh they don't, that's good. And you play there every Sunday. And you probably don't know what you're going to play when you get there, you just wait for Junior to say something. Sometimes when I'm on a gig I wish I was keeping notes like if someone asked me to play something and I didn't know it, that I should write it down and that week I should make it my business to learn it.

MF: Me too sometimes. I ask Hide, what are the changes. Even Hide says he don't know. Because he's listening. After he finishes the song, "I don't know."

MR: Yeah. "I don't know how I got through it."

MF: Right. Ask Junior. Finally, in a rehearsal, Junior also doesn't say anything, just play and listen. So finally I looked at his hands.

MR: From a video? You looked at his hands to see what chords he was playing.

MF: Yeah. And always I'm playing behind Junior. So I always see the piano. It's good training.

MR: That's interesting. Because sometimes the bass players used to do that too, look at the piano player's left hand.

MF: Yeah, I'm always watching the left hand.

MR: But usually the bass player's got to know those changes you know, because that's where it starts. Very interesting.

MF: Yeah, I'm getting in the habit, with different piano players. But I got in the habit. If it's not Junior I worry. Some piano players — you couldn't get away with this.

MR: What's it like to go back to Japan now and play?

MF: We went back last year with Junior. It's good.

MR: Yeah. Did your family come out to see you?

MF: Yeah. That was nice.

MR: Well it's been a pleasure having you here at Hamilton and I look forward to your concert tonight. Does Junior make you speak to the audience?

MF: Ut um. Even Junior not so much speak to the audience.

MR: Okay. And you've been on two or three recordings with him already.

MF: I think so. Maybe.

MR: Is it any different playing in the studio? Maybe they were live recordings.

MF: Yeah with Junior it's the three of us, it's live.

MR: Does it make you more nervous? You probably think more about what you're doing.

MF: Yeah.

MR: Well thanks for your time today, it's been a real pleasure.

MF: Okay. Thank you.